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CITY OF STALLED PROJECTS

Development takes a backseat in the zeal to rewrite the history of the erstwhile capital of the Mughal empire and rename its heritage monuments such as the Taj, with many of the city's development projects caught in purgatory

By Ashish Misra

It was meant to be a grand project, showcasing Mughal-era armour, attire, culture and related memorabilia. But take the red sandstone-topped Shilpgram Road to the eastern gate of the Taj Mahal, past the stone plaque bearing the legend 'Mughal Museum' and enter the iron gate adjacent to it, and you step into a dream that has long been abandoned.

The three-storey building on the 5.9-acre campus, 1,300 metres from the Taj's eastern gate, has been lying unfinished for almost six years now. More than two dozen expensive cassette air-conditioners lie rusting in the open, reinforcing the sense of dystopia. The complex was to have a handicrafts market, a seminar hall and an art gallery. The hall for the handicrafts market is filled with rainwater; bushes have grown around it; the stones and